Comparatives, superlatives and quantities

Understand it

Task 1 rewards comparison, not lists of numbers. Use comparatives for two items, superlatives for the extremes, and structures like twice as ... as for exact differences.

Quantity words must match the noun: countable nouns (people, cars) and uncountable nouns (water, money) take different words.

The rules

- Short adjectives: taller, the tallest. Long adjectives: more expensive, the most expensive. Irregular: better, the best; worse, the worst; farther.
- Comparison structures: twice as high as, three times more than, slightly lower than, considerably higher than, not as high as.
- Quantities: many / few (countable), much / little (uncountable), a large proportion of, a small number of, the majority of.
- Percentages and fractions: a quarter of, 25 percent of, nearly half of.

All the words and forms you need

Comparatives	higher · lower · more popular · less common · better · worse · further
Superlatives	the highest · the most popular · the least common · the best
Exact difference	twice as ... as · three times as many as · half as much as · double · triple
Size of difference	slightly · a little · marginally · considerably · significantly · substantially · far · much
Similarity	the same as · similar to · as ... as · not as ... as
Countable	many · few · a few · a number of · fewer
Uncountable	much · little · a little · an amount of · less
Proportion	a quarter · a third · half · the majority · a minority · nearly · just over · just under

Where you use it

Writing: Bar charts and tables: compare, do not list. Italy had the highest rate, while Japan had the lowest.

Speaking: Part 3: Life is easier now than it was fifty years ago.

Reading: Degree words (slightly, considerably) change the strength of a statement.

More examples

- Japan had the highest proportion of elderly people.
- Car use was twice as high as bus use.
- Slightly fewer women than men studied engineering.
- Spending on health was considerably greater in 2020.
- Just under a third of people walked to work.
- The amount of water used fell by half.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ It is more cheaper than before.	✓ It is cheaper than before.
✗ The number of cars are higher.	✓ The number of cars is higher.
✗ Less people travel by train.	✓ Fewer people travel by train.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Is life in your country better now than in the past?
2. Which is more important: money or free time?
3. What is the most beautiful place you have visited?
4. Do you spend more time online than with friends?
5. Who is the most interesting person in your family?

Writing practice

Compare: Country A: 60% cars, 30% buses, 10% bikes. Country B: 30% cars, 20% buses, 50% bikes. Write 3 sentences.

Practice

1. Complete: Of the three countries, Spain had the ___ (high) rate.

2. Complete: Cars are ___ (expensive) than bicycles.

3. Rewrite: A = 20, B = 10. A is ___ as high as B.

4. Choose: (Few / Little) people attended.

5. Correct: There was less students than last year.

6. Correct: The majority of people is happy.

Answers

1. highest
2. more expensive
3. twice
4. Few
5. There were fewer students than last year.
6. The majority of people are happy.